Yet another constraint for horticulture is the weak farmer-producer organisation (FPOs) network. FPOs can enable economies of scale, enhance operational efficiencies, promote best practices, connect farmers with (international) buyers, secure fair prices, minimise the impact of intermediaries, and build farmers' capacity to manage modern agriculture's complexities. However, their weaknesses contribute to horticulture's challenges, limiting the farmers' ability to benefit from opportunities. Recognising the need to increase the bargaining power of farmers, the government is implementing an FPO formation and promotion scheme, with an outlay of Rs 6,300 crore. Around 8,000 FPOs have been formed so far. Besides establishing crop-specific value chains, the FPOs will also focus on agri-entrepreneurship development and mentoring farmers in producing quality goods that meet global standards.

Horticulture has never had it so good, especially since it is in sync with the government's vision for agriculture in the future. A number of schemes have been launched to ensure its success, such as the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (PMKSY) to improve irrigation and reduce water waste; the Cluster Development Programmes (CDP) to get smallholders together, assist in pre-production, post-harvest logistics, branding and other issues; and the Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY) to encourage cluster-based organic farming with accreditation (training and certification). Then there's the comprehensive crop insurance coverage—from pre-sowing to post-harvest losses—with the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana, and Soil Health Cards to promote soil health. The Model Agricultural Land Leasing Act, 2016 has also helped legalise leasing and given tenants access to insurance and credit.

MARKETING LINKAGES

Horticulture export is risky because of the perishable nature of the produce. The export journey typically involves handling by multiple parties: farmers, logistics operators, customs authorities, phytosanitary (plant health and disease) inspection agencies, repackaging providers and more. This has to be undertaken in a fast, coordinated manner to ensure fresh delivery to the retailer. Poor logistics and lack of equitable cold storage and warehousing facilities contribute to delays and wastages. Existing cold storage distribution among the states is also inequitable, with nearly three-fifths of the total storage capacity (21 MT) confined to the four states of Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Gujarat and Punjab, and most of it only for the potato crop. Enhanced cold storage capacity, but one which is more spread out, will enable farmers to adjust the supply based on demand fluctuations—a crucial advantage while exporting. That said, it must also be noted that capacity utilisation at processing facilities in the country is barely 30 per cent now. This is perhaps because marketing is our weakest link. "We produce 28 million tonnes of mangoes but do not export even a tenth of it a year," says Chengal Reddy.

TAKEAWAYS

- **India is No. 2 globally in horticulture production but its share in global exports is still a measly 1.1%**
- **Horticulture contributes 30.4% to the agriculture GDP**
- **Smallholders make up 86.2% of horticulturists. It's a boon and bane—livelihood for many, but scaling up is difficult**
- **Horticulture has the Centre's backing, many schemes tailored for it now**
- **Farmers still wary of horticulture, feel it's risky compared to MSP surety of grains**
- **Marketing needs total revamp in food processing; demand slow, units working at 30% capacity**

FOOD PROCESSING

For value addition, processing and export, it is integral to appreciate what the farmer, industry and exporter want and make it accessible and available. The ministry of food processing has launched several schemes aimed at promoting the industry, including the creation of cold chain infrastructure, agro processing clusters, backward and forward linkages, preservation infrastructure, Operation Greens (integrated value chain development projects) and mega food parks. These schemes provide various facilities to food processing units, such as storage, testing labs and logistics while also stabilising the supply and prices of perishable commodities. Processing of fruits and vegetables can also be done by the One District One Product model, leveraging the strengths of region-specific produce to expand the export basket.

The diversity in Indian agriculture is mind-boggling with the amazing range of crops and agro-climatic conditions in which they are grown. But right now, there is no entity to give it direction from a national perspective like in the industry and services sectors. Says K.R. Suresh Reddy, Bharat Rashtra Samithi leader in the Rajya Sabha and MPs' Forum for Farmers convenor, "We need a mechanism, like in the US and Australia, where farmers' bureaus and farm councils assist growers, ensure they get a fair deal. Such a commission must focus entirely on farmers' issues... they are now being handled by several departments and ministries." A National Agriculture Advisory Council, comprising all stakeholders, could be the answer. To mark new beginnings and spur exports, it could maybe even declare the mango, often referred to as the king of fruits, as the fruit ambassador of India. ■